

VISUAL STORYBOARD

Handling the Heat: De-escalation Scenarios for Customer-Facing Teams

30 screens · 4 branching scenarios · Built in PowerPoint with hyperlinked navigation · No audio narration



Dark Teal



Primary Teal



Mint Accent



Orange CTA

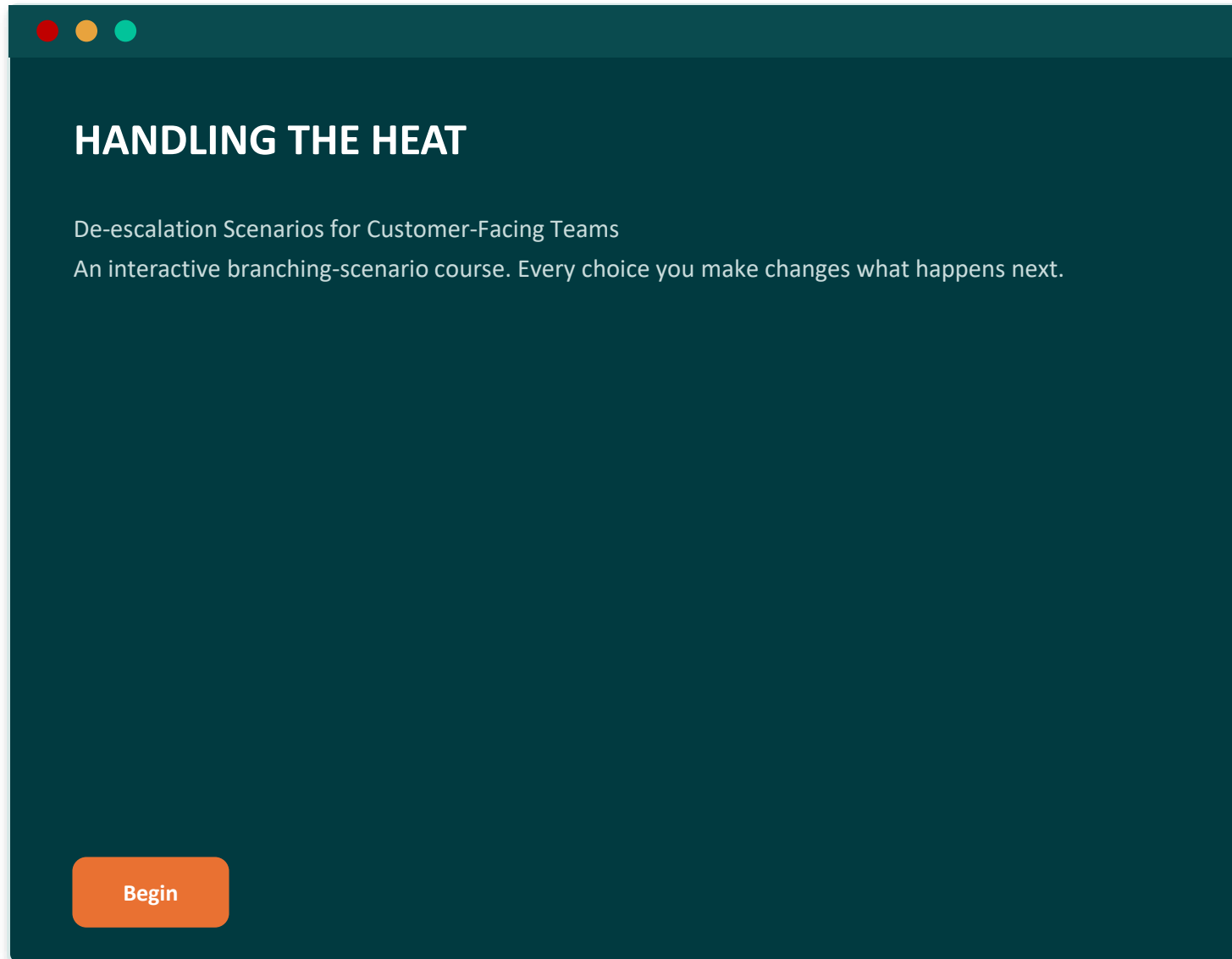


Poor



Partial

Title Screen



VISUAL

Dark teal full-bleed background. Small orange eyebrow label top-left. Large bold serif headline, sub-line below in muted white. Orange 'Begin' button lower-left.

INTERACTION

Click Begin to enter the course.

NAVIGATION

Begin → Screen 2

DEV NOTES

No audio. Course title slide; sets tone and visual identity (dark teal + orange).

How This Course Works

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1. Read the scenario — Meet a customer and the situation they're bringing to you.
2. Choose the response — Click one of three responses; some choices work better than others.
3. See what happens — Get honest feedback on why a response helped or hurt.
4. Try again if needed — Weaker choices send you back to try again, no penalty.

Click here to continue

VISUAL

Light background. Four numbered rows (1-4), each with a bold heading and a short description line, laid out in a 2x2 or stacked grid.

INTERACTION

Click Continue to proceed. No branching on this screen — orientation only.

NAVIGATION

Continue → Screen 3

DEV NOTES

Purely instructional; establishes the rules of engagement before objectives.

Learning Objectives

Learning Objectives

By the end of this course, you'll be able to:

- Recognize the difference between reacting to a customer and responding to them
- Acknowledge a customer's emotions before jumping to a fix
- Take ownership of a problem instead of deflecting or passing it along
- Hold a policy boundary firmly while still offering the customer a way forward

Click here to continue

VISUAL

Light background. Title top-left, four objective bars/rows stacked vertically, each in a colored highlight bar for scannability.

INTERACTION

Click Continue to proceed.

NAVIGATION

Continue → Screen 4

DEV NOTES

Standard objectives screen. No interactivity beyond linear continue.

Keep C.A.L.M.

You'll see this pattern in every scenario ahead.

C — Center Yourself: Pause before you respond. Your tone matters as much as your words.

A — Acknowledge: Name what the customer is feeling before you move to a solution.

L — Listen Fully: Let them finish. Don't plan your rebuttal while they're still talking.

M — Move Forward: Offer a concrete next step — together, not at them.

Click here to continue

VISUAL

Dark teal background. Four equal-width cards in a row, each with a large circular letter badge (C/A/L/M), a bold title, and a short description.

INTERACTION

Click Continue to proceed.

NAVIGATION

Continue → Screen 5 (Scenario Menu)

DEV NOTES

This is the recurring mental model referenced in every debrief screen — keep iconography/lettering consistent throughout the deck.

Scenario Menu (Hub)



Choose Where to Start

Every path returns here, so feel free to explore them in any order.

01 The Angry Caller — A billing error, and a customer who's already raised his voice. [Start Scenario 1]

02 The Repeat Complainer — Third call, same issue — and fading patience. [Start Scenario 2]

03 The Unreasonable Request — A policy line, and a threat to walk away unhappy. [Start Scenario 3]

★ Final Challenge — Put every skill together in one live chat conversation. [Go to Final Challenge]

VISUAL

Light background. Four cards in a row, three light-teal-tinted, the Final Challenge card in dark teal to visually set it apart. Each card: number/star, title, one-line description, Start button.

INTERACTION

Click any card's Start button to jump into that scenario. Non-linear hub — learner may take any order.

NAVIGATION

Start Scenario 1 → Screen 6 | Start Scenario 2 → Screen 12 | Start Scenario 3 → Screen 18 | Final Challenge → Screen 24

DEV NOTES

Every scenario debrief screen links back here, so this is the true 'home base' of the course. All 4 destinations must be live hyperlinks.

Scenario 1 – Persona (The Angry Caller)

The Angry Caller — Scenario 1

Jordan, Customer

Jordan calls in, upset about being billed twice for the same order.

“You people charged me twice! This is ridiculous — I want this fixed right now!”

Your Task: Read the situation, then choose how you'd respond in the moment. There's no perfect script — only choices that build trust, and choices that break it.

Scenario Menu

Begin

VISUAL

Light background. Left card: avatar circle with initial 'J', name/role, context line, quote in a speech-bubble box. Right column: 'Your Task' framing text.

INTERACTION

Begin advances into the decision point. Scenario Menu returns to the hub at any time.

NAVIGATION

Begin → Screen 7 | Scenario Menu → Screen 5

DEV NOTES

Persona template reused for every scenario — only name, avatar initial, context, and quote change.

Scenario 1 – Decision Point

How do you respond first?

“You people charged me twice! This is ridiculous — I want this fixed right now!”

A. “Sir, I need you to calm down so I can help you.”

B. “I can process a refund for you right now.”

C. “I hear how frustrating that is — I'd be upset too. Let's fix this together. Can you confirm the order number?”

VISUAL

Light background. Customer's line repeated in a dark banner at top for context. Three response options stacked as clickable cards, lettered A/B/C.

INTERACTION

Learner clicks one of three response cards. Each choice routes to its own feedback screen.

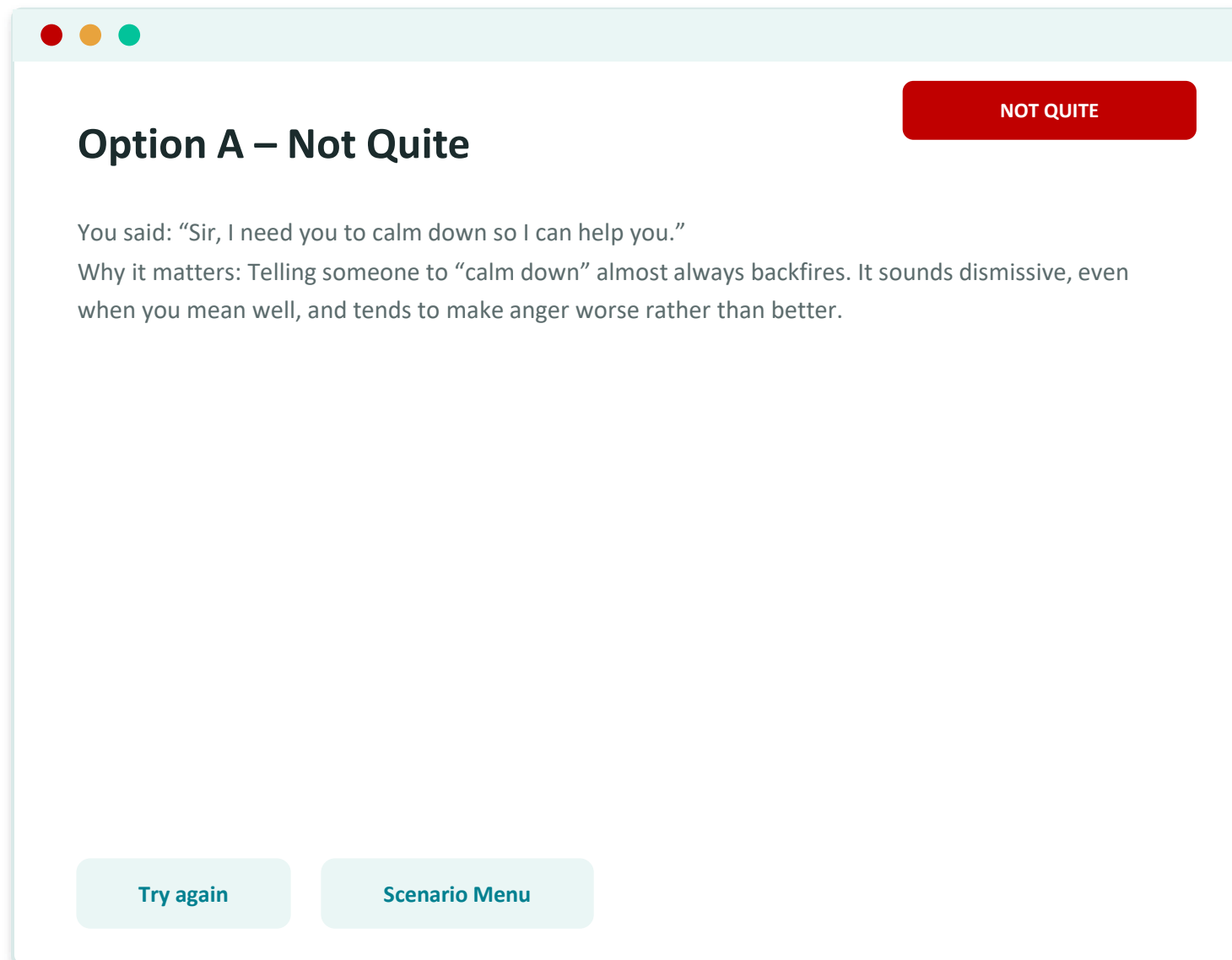
NAVIGATION

A → Screen 8 | B → Screen 9 | C → Screen 10

DEV NOTES

Core branching decision. All three choice regions must be fully clickable hotspots, not just the letter badge.

Scenario 1 – Feedback A (Not Quite)



VISUAL

Light background. Red 'Not Quite' badge top-right. Chosen response quoted in a box. Feedback explanation below in a highlighted panel. Red 'Try again' button.

INTERACTION

Try Again returns to the decision point so the learner can pick a different response. Scenario Menu exits to hub.

NAVIGATION

Try again → Screen 7 | Scenario Menu → Screen 5

DEV NOTES

Weak-choice feedback pattern (red badge + Try Again) is reused across all scenarios for the 'poor' option.

ROOM TO IMPROVE

Option B – Room to Improve

You said: “I can process a refund for you right now.”

Why it matters: Solving the problem fast is a good instinct — but jumping straight to a fix without acknowledging how Jordan feels can come across as transactional. He may still feel unheard.

Try again

Scenario Menu

VISUAL

Same template as Feedback A, but badge and Try Again button in amber/gold to signal 'partial credit' rather than fully wrong.

INTERACTION

Try Again returns to the decision point. Scenario Menu exits to hub.

NAVIGATION

Try again → Screen 7 | Scenario Menu → Screen 5

DEV NOTES

Amber 'partial' feedback pattern reused across all scenarios for the middle option.

Scenario 1 – Feedback C (Strong Response)

STRONG RESPONSE

Option C – Strong Response

You said: “I hear how frustrating that is — I'd be upset too. Let's fix this together. Can you confirm the order number?”

Why it matters: You acknowledged the emotion before moving to action. That lowers defensiveness and builds trust before you've even solved the problem.

Continue

Scenario Menu

VISUAL

Same template, badge and button in teal/green 'Strong Response' styling. Continue button (not Try Again) since this is the correct path forward.

INTERACTION

Continue advances to the scenario debrief. Scenario Menu exits to hub.

NAVIGATION

Continue → Screen 11 | Scenario Menu → Screen 5

DEV NOTES

Only the 'best' choice unlocks forward progress — confirms this is the sole exit from the decision loop.

Scenario 1 – Debrief

Scenario 1: Debrief

ACKNOWLEDGE FIRST, THEN ACT.

Skipping straight to a solution can feel efficient, but it often leaves the customer feeling unheard. A brief acknowledgment costs you seconds and buys you trust.

Click here to continue

Scenario Menu

VISUAL

Dark teal background (matches Title/Framework screens — signals a 'milestone' moment). Bold takeaway headline, supporting paragraph below.

INTERACTION

Continue advances to the next scenario. Scenario Menu returns to hub instead.

NAVIGATION

Continue → Screen 12 (Scenario 2) | Scenario Menu → Screen 5

DEV NOTES

Debrief template reused for every scenario — only headline/body text and destination change.

Scenario 2 – Persona (The Repeat Complainer)

The Repeat Complainer — Scenario 2

Priya, Customer

This is Priya's third call about the same unresolved shipping issue.

“This is the THIRD time I'm calling about this. Nobody has fixed it. Why should I believe you're any different?”

Your Task: Read the situation, then choose how you'd respond in the moment.

Scenario Menu

Begin

VISUAL

Same persona template as Screen 6, avatar initial 'P'.

INTERACTION

Begin advances into the decision point. Scenario Menu returns to hub.

NAVIGATION

Begin → Screen 13 | Scenario Menu → Screen 5

DEV NOTES

Reused template.

Scenario 2 – Decision Point

How do you respond first?

“This is the THIRD time I'm calling about this. Nobody has fixed it. Why should I believe you're any different?”

A. “I don't see any notes on your account — can you explain the issue again from the start?”

B. “I'm sorry about that. I'll pass this along to the right team.”

C. “I can see this has been frustrating. I'll personally follow up until it's resolved. Let me pull up your account now.”

VISUAL

Same decision template as Screen 7.

INTERACTION

Learner clicks one of three response cards.

NAVIGATION

A → Screen 14 | B → Screen 15 | C → Screen 16

DEV NOTES

Reused template.

Scenario 2 – Feedback A (Not Quite)

Option A – Not Quite

NOT QUITE

You said: “I don't see any notes on your account — can you explain the issue again from the start?”

Why it matters: Asking Priya to repeat her story a third time reinforces exactly what she's upset about: feeling ignored and passed around.

Try again

Scenario Menu

VISUAL

Red feedback template (same as Screen 8).

INTERACTION

Try Again returns to decision point.

NAVIGATION

Try again → Screen 13 | Scenario Menu → Screen 5

DEV NOTES

Reused template.

Scenario 2 – Feedback B (Room to Improve)

ROOM TO IMPROVE

Option B – Room to Improve

You said: “I’m sorry about that. I’ll pass this along to the right team.”

Why it matters: This is polite, but vague. “I’ll pass it along” is the same promise that already failed twice — it won’t rebuild trust on its own.

Try again

Scenario Menu

VISUAL

Amber feedback template (same as Screen 9).

INTERACTION

Try Again returns to decision point.

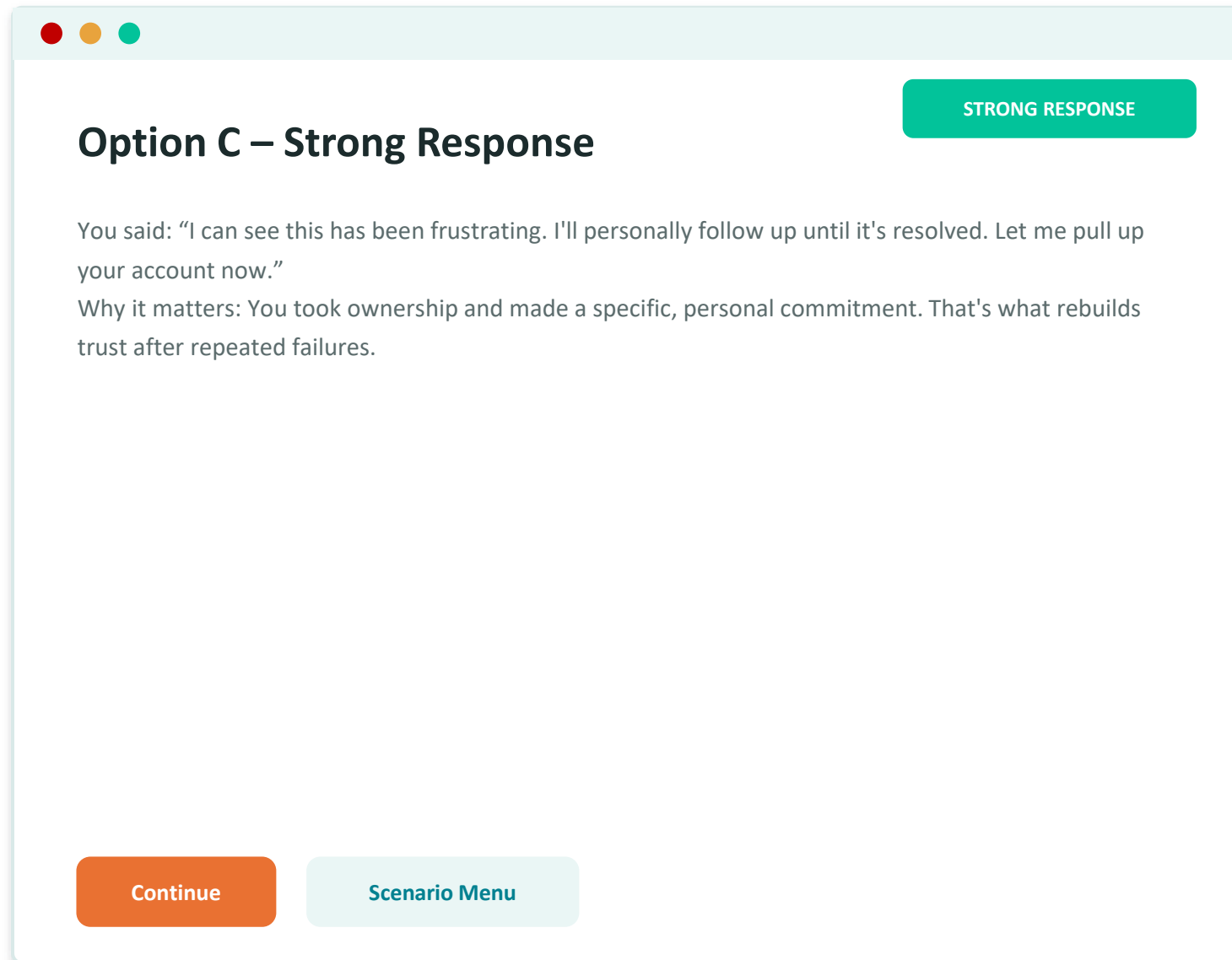
NAVIGATION

Try again → Screen 13 | Scenario Menu → Screen 5

DEV NOTES

Reused template.

Scenario 2 – Feedback C (Strong Response)



VISUAL

Teal/green feedback template (same as Screen 10).

INTERACTION

Continue advances to debrief.

NAVIGATION

Continue → Screen 17 | Scenario Menu → Screen 5

DEV NOTES

Reused template.

Scenario 2 – Debrief

Scenario 2: Debrief

OWNERSHIP BEATS APOLOGY.

When a customer has already been let down twice, a generic apology won't land. Specific commitments — and following through on them — are what rebuild trust.

Click here to continue

Scenario Menu

VISUAL

Dark teal debrief template (same as Screen 11).

INTERACTION

Continue advances to the next scenario. Scenario Menu returns to hub.

NAVIGATION

Continue → Screen 18 (Scenario 3) | Scenario Menu → Screen 5

DEV NOTES

Reused template.

Scenario 3 – Persona (The Unreasonable Request)

The Unreasonable Request — Scenario 3

Sam, Customer

Sam wants a refund on a product returned 60 days past the deadline, and threatens a negative review. “I know it's late, but I want my money back today — or I'm leaving a one-star review everywhere I can.”
Your Task: Read the situation, then choose how you'd respond in the moment.

Scenario Menu

Begin

VISUAL

Same persona template, avatar initial 'S'.

INTERACTION

Begin advances into the decision point. Scenario Menu returns to hub.

NAVIGATION

Begin → Screen 19 | Scenario Menu → Screen 5

DEV NOTES

Reused template.

Scenario 3 – Decision Point



How do you respond first?

“I know it's late, but I want my money back today — or I'm leaving a one-star review everywhere I can.”

A. “Okay, I'll go ahead and process that refund for you.”

B. “I'm sorry, that's against policy. There's nothing I can do.”

C. “I understand that it feels unfair. I can't refund past the window, but I can offer store credit. Let's find something that works.”

VISUAL

Same decision template.

INTERACTION

Learner clicks one of three response cards.

NAVIGATION

A → Screen 20 | B → Screen 21 | C → Screen 22

DEV NOTES

Reused template.

Scenario 3 – Feedback A (Not Quite)

Option A – Not Quite

NOT QUITE

You said: “Okay, I’ll go ahead and process that refund for you.”

Why it matters: Giving in to a threat feels like the fastest way to end the conflict, but it isn’t sustainable — and it doesn’t actually build genuine trust.

Try again

Scenario Menu

VISUAL

Red feedback template.

INTERACTION

Try Again returns to decision point.

NAVIGATION

Try again → Screen 19 | Scenario Menu → Screen 5

DEV NOTES

Reused template.

Scenario 3 – Feedback B (Room to Improve)

ROOM TO IMPROVE

Option B – Room to Improve

You said: “I’m sorry, that’s against policy. There’s nothing I can do.”

Why it matters: A flat refusal without explanation or alternative feels dismissive. It’s honest, but it raises — not lowers — the odds of that negative review.

Try again

Scenario Menu

VISUAL

Amber feedback template.

INTERACTION

Try Again returns to decision point.

NAVIGATION

Try again → Screen 19 | Scenario Menu → Screen 5

DEV NOTES

Reused template.

Scenario 3 – Feedback C (Strong Response)

STRONG RESPONSE

Option C – Strong Response

You said: “I understand that it feels unfair. I can't refund past the window, but I can offer store credit. Let's find something that works.”

Why it matters: You held the boundary and offered a real alternative. De-escalation isn't about giving in — it's about staying firm while still moving toward a solution.

Continue

Scenario Menu

VISUAL

Teal/green feedback template.

INTERACTION

Continue advances to debrief.

NAVIGATION

Continue → Screen 23 | Scenario Menu → Screen 5

DEV NOTES

Reused template.

Scenario 3 – Debrief

Scenario 3: Debrief

HOLD THE BOUNDARY, OFFER A PATH.
You don't have to say yes to de-escalate. Explaining the “why” and offering an alternative respects both the policy and the relationship.

Click here to continue

Scenario Menu

VISUAL

Dark teal debrief template.

INTERACTION

Continue advances to the Final Challenge. Scenario Menu returns to hub.

NAVIGATION

Continue → Screen 24 (Final Challenge) | Scenario Menu → Screen 5

DEV NOTES

Reused template. Last of the three core scenarios — routes into the capstone challenge.

Final Challenge – Persona

Put It All Together — Final Challenge

Alex, Customer

Alex is messaging in live chat, clearly frustrated, in short clipped sentences.

“This is a joke. Fix it or I'm done.”

Your Task: Read the situation, then choose how you'd respond in the moment.

Scenario Menu

Begin

VISUAL

Same persona template, avatar initial 'A'. Labeled 'Final Challenge' instead of a scenario number to signal capstone status.

INTERACTION

Begin advances into the decision point. Scenario Menu returns to hub.

NAVIGATION

Begin → Screen 25 | Scenario Menu → Screen 5

DEV NOTES

Reused template. Live-chat framing (not phone call) — shorter, clipped customer message reflects text-chat tone.

Final Challenge – Decision Point



You have one message to turn this around. What do you send?

“This is a joke. Fix it or I'm done.”

A. “Can you tell me more about the issue you're having?”

B. “Sorry for the trouble! I'll look into it.”

C. “That sounds really frustrating, and I want to make this right. I'm looking into your account right now and won't leave this chat until we have an answer.”

VISUAL

Same decision template.

INTERACTION

Learner clicks one of three response cards.

NAVIGATION

A → Screen 26 | B → Screen 27 | C → Screen 28

DEV NOTES

Reused template. This decision synthesizes all three prior skills (acknowledge, ownership, boundary/commitment) into one message.

Final Challenge – Feedback A (Not Quite)

Option A – Not Quite

NOT QUITE

You said: “Can you tell me more about the issue you're having?”

Why it matters: Not wrong, but it ignores Alex's frustration entirely. Jumping straight into fact-finding without any acknowledgment can feel cold, especially in text.

Try again

Scenario Menu

VISUAL

Red feedback template.

INTERACTION

Try Again returns to decision point.

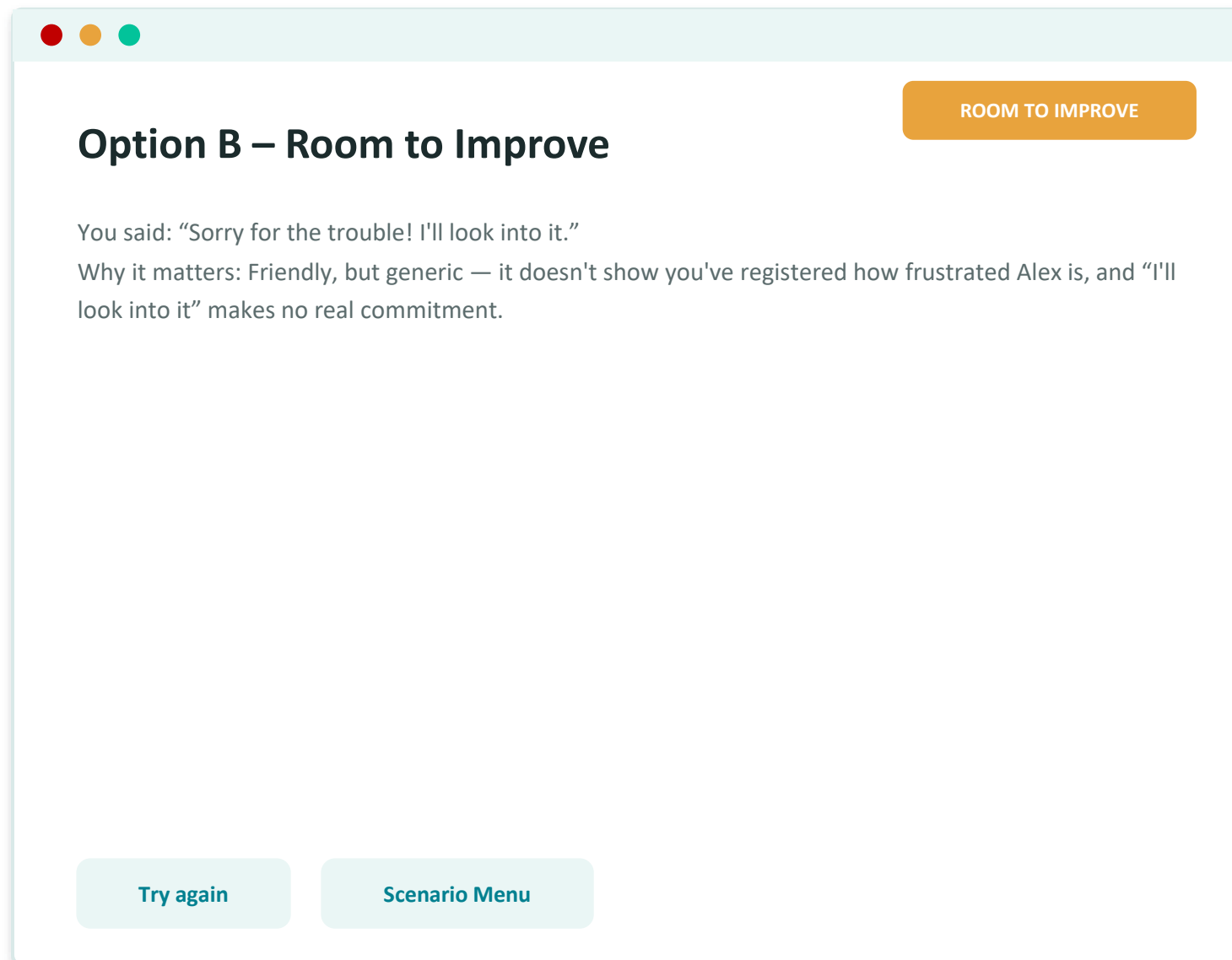
NAVIGATION

Try again → Screen 25 | Scenario Menu → Screen 5

DEV NOTES

Reused template.

Final Challenge – Feedback B (Room to Improve)



VISUAL

Amber feedback template.

INTERACTION

Try Again returns to decision point.

NAVIGATION

Try again → Screen 25 | Scenario Menu → Screen 5

DEV NOTES

Reused template.

Final Challenge – Feedback C (Strong Response)

Option C – Strong Response

STRONG RESPONSE

You said: “That sounds really frustrating, and I want to make this right. I'm looking into your account right now and won't leave this chat until we have an answer.”

Why it matters: You combined acknowledgment, ownership, and a concrete commitment — the full C.A.L.M. approach, in one message.

Continue

Scenario Menu

VISUAL

Teal/green feedback template.

INTERACTION

Continue advances to final debrief.

NAVIGATION

Continue → Screen 29 | Scenario Menu → Screen 5

DEV NOTES

Reused template. Explicitly ties the response back to the C.A.L.M. framework from Screen 4.

Final Challenge – Debrief

Final Challenge: Debrief

YOU'VE GOT THIS.

Center yourself, Acknowledge the feeling, Listen fully, and Move toward a solution together. Every difficult conversation gets easier in that order.

See your Result

Scenario Menu

VISUAL

Dark teal debrief template.

INTERACTION

See your Result advances to the completion screen. Scenario Menu returns to hub.

NAVIGATION

See your Result → Screen 30 | Scenario Menu → Screen 5

DEV NOTES

Final debrief before course completion; button label changes from 'Continue' to 'See your Result' to signal this is the last step.

Course Complete

Course Complete

You've worked through every scenario. The next real conversation is the one that counts — carry C.A.L.M. with you.

[Recap chips] Center | Acknowledge | Listen | Move Forward

Restart Course

VISUAL

Dark teal background, centered layout. Large star icon/badge at top, headline, supporting line, four small recap chips summarizing C.A.L.M., orange Restart button.

INTERACTION

Restart Course returns the learner to the Scenario Menu to revisit any path.

NAVIGATION

Restart Course → Screen 5

DEV NOTES

Final screen of the course. No further branching. Confirms completion; no scoring/certificate mechanism in this version.